



Do It Yourself Radio Promotion – Commercial Radio

Before we get into how to get your music on commercial radio, make sure you check out the “Radio Formats 101” download included in this Toolkit.

Part 1: Doing it with \$0 Manually

Part 2: Doing it with a few hundred \$\$ Using DMDS

Part 1: Manual Radio Promotion

Back in January of 2015 I tried for the very first time to get one of my management clients’ new singles on commercial Top 40 radio in Canada, by myself, with zero dollars. I had no idea what I was doing, but long story short, within 3 days we had our first radio add, and within a couple months the single ended up reaching the top 10 to 15 on multiple charts including Billboard AC and Billboard Top 40, Mediabase Hot AC, Shazam, and iTunes. 9 months later, after the song had already charted, the artist hired a promoter to help tip it up a bit, and the song subsequently went certified Platinum a year and a half later. As of today, in July of 2018, that song has over 2.5 million streams on Spotify, the remix of it has over 5 and a half million streams, and all her songs combined have over 40 million streams on Spotify.

Let me back it up and paint the picture for you a little bit... at the time we released that song, this artist was not signed to a label, we did not have the money to pay a radio promoter, she wasn’t signed to a large well-known management company, I was managing her independently and was still a relatively new manager at the time with no idea how to get songs on the radio, she had zero songs on the radio previously, it was her first EVER release as a solo artist, the duo she was in before-hand was not on the radio, and she had maybe performed a live show or two as a solo artist.

Basically, all odds were stacked against her for getting her music on the radio, and not just on the radio, but TOP 40 RADIO. Now it may have been luck, and it may have been timing, and it may have been other things, but what I think it really comes down to is the fact that it was a great song, with great production, a great beat, a great voice, it fit the radio format perfectly, but it sounded different than everything else.

Now that happened to be the one and only time I’ve ever fully done radio promotion by myself. Every other artist I’ve worked with who is a commercial radio artist, we had either a record label or an independent radio promoter doing the work for us. So, through all my personal experience, I’m going to share with you how you can try to do the same and get your first radio add. And if you don’t know what radio add means, it means they’ve added your single to rotation, as opposed to a “feature” where they just feature the song once and then consider if they want to “add” it.



Now don't get me wrong, I'm not saying it's easy to get your songs on the radio. I'm also not saying you don't need a label or extra promotion help to get you on the radio. This process is significantly easier and more efficient when you have money, or a label, or a radio promoter. But that's not what this is about, so let's talk about how to do it when you have NO MONEY, NO LABEL, and NO PROMOTER, but a little bit of time.

However, with even as little as just a couple hundred bucks you can pay to distribute your songs through DMDS yourself. Or you can pay a couple thousand bucks to hire a radio promoter to do everything for you. With radio promoters, there is still no guarantee you'll get on the radio or chart. I've had a lot of success with radio promoters, and I've also done worse than I did on my own with a radio promoter. It comes down to a few factors – first and foremost – the song!

1. Have an Ear for Radio Hits

The first step is to have an ear for radio hits. The concept of getting your music on the radio is not meant for you if you do not have great songs, and great RADIO Songs. I've talked before about making sure the artist WRITES a radio hit, but I want to clarify that. What I really want you take away with you, whether you're the artist or the manager, whether you've written the song specifically for radio or you're just naturally a hit maker, is that you must be so sure that your song is a radio hit. Because you're not going to get your song on the radio if it's not a radio song or doesn't fit into a radio format.

There are about 18 formats in the US and 7 formats in Canada. Technically, formats are just genres but there's more to it than that. Either way, study artists and songs that are on the radio, that are on the stations you want to be on, that are within your format, analyze their writing skills and figure out what is getting them on the radio. I'm sure you can tell the difference between songs on an artists' album that end up on the radio and songs that don't. Some songs are meant for radio and some aren't.

If you're the artist, see how you can write in your own authentic way, but that will connect with the masses and have hooks and beats like radio does. If you're the manager, just learn to have a good ear and be able to pick out a radio song when you hear one. And if neither of you can do this, maybe radio is not for you. Which is fine!

2. Start Your Radio Contact Database

Create an excel sheet with:

- Location – Broadcaster – Station – Contact Info – Contacted – Response



Begin to create your own database of major and small market stations based around your format. You can find all the major stations by Googling the broadcasters name with something like “Bell Radio Stations”, and so on:

- Bell Media
- Harvard Broadcasting
- Rogers
- Newcap
- Jim Pattison
- And any others that you can find or know about

Scroll through each of their stations and pick out the ones that fit your music style / format

Visit the station website and click on the contact or about page.

Fill out your database with the location of the station, the name of the broadcaster, the station name and number, and contact info for the Music Director or Program Director.

If the contact information isn’t listed on the website, CALL THE STATION AND ASK FOR IT.

At absolute least you should get the Music Directors contact information. Every single station I called happily gave me their Music Directors email and phone number. If you want to take it a step further than I did, you could also contact the Program Director, General Manager, and On Air Talent. They all get together for music meetings once a week, so you shouldn’t need to contact everyone, but it can’t hurt to go at it from all angles.

BONUS TIP: DMDS has a list of all stations sorted by format [here](#). Google all those stations and collect information that way!

3. Start Contacting Your Contacts

Call or email. Sometimes I just don’t like calling people when I know they aren’t expecting it, and I know some people don’t like being called out of the blue. It’s probably best if you email them first. Keep it short. I include:

- A longer subject line with artist name, song name, location
- Something notable about the song or the artist
- That it’s CANCON
- Link to the song
- Link to the artist EPK



Make sure you add the dates you contacted them in your database!

4. Wait It Out & Gain Thick Skin

Yes, this is a real and important step so listen up because I'm trying to manage your expectations here. Building the database was the "easy" part. Once you get the contact information there are still many other waiting factors, such as:

- Waiting for your contact person to listen
- Waiting for that person to take the song into their weekly music meeting
- Hoping the team likes the song
- Waiting for your contact person to respond to let you know if they liked it
- **If 50 other major label artists have just released new singles, you're basically screwed*
- Hoping they like it enough that they'll feature it or add it to rotation
- Hoping that radio listeners will like it, Shazam it, request it, and then buy it!

Waiting, hoping, waiting, hoping.

As for thick skin, music directors aren't scared to tell the manager (or the artist) or whoever is sending the single to radio, if the song sucks or is not a good fit. Be prepared to take criticism and do not fight back. It's their opinion over yours.

5. Follow Up & Build Relationships

Continue to build relationships with the station directors and on-air staff. Ideally, you're only following up when you have something new to tell them – like a new radio add on another station. But if you just want to check in to see if they've listened to it yet, then I would say contact them a couple weeks after your first email.

Additionally, it's always important to get to know people. If you have the opportunity, get to know the radio station directors, they are the ones that can make or break your career. As for the ones that actually add your music, forever treat them like family. Stay in touch with them.

When you're out at music functions, try to meet them and build genuine friendships. And not just radio but every kind of music industry person possible. Your contacts are your biggest asset next to your talent.

6. Send Your Song to Mediabase

Send your mp3 to encoding@mediabase.com asap. Include the artist name, song title, label name (or Indie) and if the song is Canadian Content (Cancon/MAPL) and the radio release date.



Now, I would suggest you send your song to this email before getting radio play, no matter your genre. It might make their lives easier so they don't have to track you down. If you're wondering how you get reports from Mediabase, it'll cost about \$200 US per month to be a subscriber if you're an independent.

In summary, none of this is possible unless you truly have an amazing song that fits on radio. So make sure you have an ear for that, know your formats, find the station music directors, build relationships, send them your song, wait for their feedback and keep trying.

Part 2: Radio Promotion Using DMDS

Doing it manually (emailing) is quite labourous and takes a LOT of time. Unless radio promotion is your full-time job, then you may want to head to DMDS for a little assistance. OR, you may want to manually submit to radio directors, AS WELL AS through DMDS. Yes, it's lot of work.

What is DMDS?

DMDS (Digital Media Distribution System) delivers your music tracks and promo materials directly to the email inboxes of music programmers at radio stations in Canada and the US. It's free to register and only takes a few moments. What they do is develop "destination packages" that are categorized by each radio format, so when you want to send your music to a certain format (in short, where your style of music fits in), you select that package, pay for it, and they instantly ship it off to those stations/contacts. They also give you the option of targeting BDS/Mediabase monitored stations (the stations where spins are monitored to create radio format charts), or sending to all stations within your format.

Essentially, they've done all the dirty work for you (finding radio stations that fit your music style, finding the emails of the music directors, packaged up a nice email to send to them).

What Do the Music Directors Think Of DMDS?

In my book [The Music Business For Artist Managers and Self-Managed Artists: All You Need To Know To Get Started, Get Noticed, and Get Signed](#), I asked dozens of Music Directors and Program Directors at various radio stations what they think of radio promotion using DMDS, and if they prefer DMDS or manual emails directly from the artist/manager/label/promoter. Some of them said they prefer DMDS by far and that it's the best tool to use to get music to them. Some said that sometimes the songs from DMDS don't fit their format. Some say they only like DMDS if the songs are coming from a major label. Some say it doesn't make a difference to them. And finally, some say that they like DMDS AND a personal email as well. To



find out more advice from the radio programmers, as well as radio promoters and many other people in the business for how to get your music out there, check out my book.

Smarturl.it/am-book

How to Use DMDS

First you need to sign up and create a profile for your organization (usually a label or radio promoter – but it's just lonely old me in this case). Signing up is free and only takes a few moments. Once you confirm your registration, you'll want to start uploading all of your information. The links on the website to upload wouldn't work for me, so I downloaded the DMDS app for the computer – it makes uploading your music easy and fast – and only takes a few minutes to download depending on your internet connection.

What You'll Need

Song File (must be WAV), Song Art, Song Title, Artist, Album, UPC and ISRC Codes, Length, Genre, Composer, Track no, Disc no, Songwriter, Publisher, Producer, Contributing artists, Website, Video Link, Publicity, Copyright owners, Lyrics rating (explicit vs. non explicit), Copyright date (the date it was written), BMP, Intro and Outro (cold, fadeout, cold fade), Grid number, CANCON: Full, Partial or Non for each category of MAPL.

Make sure you **upload the absolute best quality files** of both the songs and your artwork. UPC / ISRC: These codes are automatically created once you register your song for distribution. See the ISRC and UPC guide included in this kit.

We use TuneCore – so I logged in to retrieve the codes from there. You can also get them before you upload the song for distribution. Contact your distribution service to find out how.

CANCON: To count as Canadian Content (which has its perks) your song must fulfill 2 of the MAPL categories. Music, Artist, Performance, Lyrics. Meaning it must have been written or recorded in Canada, or the artist must be from Canada. See CANCON guide included in this kit.

How Much It Costs

DMDS pricing is dependent on the number of destinations in each package. Destination = each radio station/organization in the package. If there are multiple persons at these stations DMDS delivers to all of them. Each format costs anywhere from \$50 – \$600. Meaning they'll distribute the song to all stations across Canada or US (whichever you choose) that fit that format. For example, Canada CHR/Top 40 Format costs \$495, which includes 149 radio stations across the country.



List of Radio Formats and DMDS Costs

This list is directly from DMDS and describes what each format includes and how much it'll cost to send your music to them. NOTE: AC, for example, is one format. You only need to select either 1) Full Format, or 2) Top 50. Full format includes all the Top 50 as well. [For a list of each station within each format click here.](#)

Canada – AC (Full Format) \$595

Adult Contemporary (AC) radio stations across Canada. These stations play adult oriented popular songs that are hits from other formats. With few exceptions, there is no rap or rock programmed at these stations. Core artists include Michael Buble and Celine Dion, but include artists that have crossed over from the Top 40 and Hot AC stations. AC radio stations are usually the first to play Holiday Music, some beginning around Thanksgiving. (219 Destinations)

Canada – AC (Top 50) \$150

Adult Contemporary (AC) radio stations in the top Canadian markets. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored AC stations.

Canada – Active Rock Top 50 \$150

The top 50 Active Rock destinations in Canada, including all BDS and Mediabase monitored stations. Core artists include Nickelback, Three Days Grace, Disturbed, and some Metal by artist such as Metallica and Pantera.

Canada – Alt/Modern Rock Top 30 \$90

The Top 30 Alternative/Modern Rock destinations in Canada, including all BDS and Mediabase monitored radio stations. Core artists include Coldplay, Kings of Leon, Cage the Elephant, Black Keys.

Canada – Campus/Community (Full Format) \$195

University, college, and non-commercial community stations across Canada. These stations play all genres of music. (68 Destinations)

Canada – CHR/Top 40 (Full Format) \$465

Contemporary Hit Radio (CHR)/Top 40 stations across Canada that play the current hits. These stations play the best of Pop, Rhythm, Alternative and more. (159 Destinations)

Canada – CHR/Top 40 (Top 40) \$120

Contemporary Hit Radio (CHR)/Top 40 radio stations in the top Canadian markets. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored Top 40 stations.

Canada – Christian (Full Format) \$120

Contemporary Christian format stations in Canada. These stations play Christian focused music in a variety of subgenres – rock, adult, country, and rhythmic. (42 Destinations)

Canada – Country (Full Format) \$475

Country stations across Canada. These stations play artists like Paul Brandt, Carrie Underwood, and Lady Antebellum. (163 Destinations)

Canada – Country (Top 50) \$150

Country radio stations in the top Canadian markets. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored Country stations.



Canada – French (Full Format) \$335

French language music stations across Canada. These stations play a variety of genres including artists like Boom Desjardins, Marie-Mai, and many English Top 40 and Rock songs. (114 Destinations)

Canada – Hot AC (Full Format) \$475

Hot AC radio stations across Canada. These stations play adult hits from artists such as John Mayer, Natasha Bedingfield, and Maroon 5. (203 Destinations)

Canada – Hot AC (Top 50) \$150

Hot AC radio stations in the top Canadian markets. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored Hot AC stations.

Canada – Jazz (Full Format) \$50

Smooth Jazz and Traditional Jazz radio stations across Canada. These stations play music from artists such as Herbie Hancock, Joe Locke, and Norah Jones. (17 Destinations)

Canada – Programming Consultants \$95

Radio programming consultants based in Canada. Many programmers rely on the advice of consultants in deciding which songs to add to rotation.

Canada – Rock (Full Format) \$595

Rock radio stations across Canada. These stations play music from artists like Billy Talent, Foo Fighters, System of a Down, and Linkin Park. (214 Destinations)

Canada – Rock (Top 50) \$150

Rock radio stations in the top Canadian markets. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored Rock stations.

Canada – Urban (Full Format) \$130

Programmers at Hip Hop/R&B/Urban/Rhythmic radio stations across Canada. These stations play artists such as Kanye West, Jilly Black, and Chris Brown. (45 Destinations)

Christmas Radio (CAN) \$295

More than 80 radio stations across Canada that requested inclusion on a list to receive new Christmas/Holiday themed music for airplay consideration on their seasonal playlist

Christmas Radio (USA) \$100

More than 55 radio stations across the US that requested inclusion on a list to receive new Christmas/Holiday themed music for airplay consideration on their seasonal playlist

USA – AC (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Adult Contemporary (AC) stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored stations. These stations play adult oriented popular songs that are hits from other formats. With few exceptions there is no rap or rock programmed at these stations. Core artists include Michael Buble and Celine Dion, but include artists that have crossed over from the Top 40 and Hot AC stations. AC radio stations are usually the first to play Holiday Music, some beginning around Thanksgiving.

USA – Active Rock (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Active Rock stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored Active Rock stations. These stations rock harder than the alternative outlets, but there is overlap of songs at both formats. Core artists include Seether, Disturbed, Avenged Sevenfold.



USA – Alternative Rock (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Alt Rock stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored radio stations. These stations play the alternative hits from current artists like Foo Fighters, Black Keys, Cage the Elephant.

USA – CHR/Top 40 (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Contemporary Hit Radio (CHR)/Top 40 stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored stations that play the current hits. These stations play the best of Pop, Rhythm, Alternative and more.

USA – Classic Rock (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Classic Rock stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored stations. These stations play the Classic Rock hits from the last 25 years. Some new tracks from core artists do get programmed. Led Zeppelin, The Rolling Stones, Bruce Springsteen, Pink Floyd, Metallica and more are featured at these stations.

USA – College (Top 100) \$295

100 of the top College radio stations across the country including Mediaguide monitored stations and those with the biggest markets and/or signal power. These stations generally have multiple DJs who program many styles of music into their individual shows. Many of these stations have Block programming, which includes several hours of a certain style of music each week, including Alternative, Rock, Acoustic, Americana, Dance, Reggae, Hip Hop, Jazz, Urban, Electronic, and more.

USA – Contemporary Christian (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Contemporary Christian stations in the US. Includes all BDS monitored stations, and smaller market Indicator stations. Current core artists include Casting Crowns, MercyMe, Amy Grant, Needtobreathe, Flyleaf, Switchfoot.

USA – Country (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Country stations in the US. Includes 100 of the most prominent BDS/Mediabase monitored stations. Core artists include Brad Paisley, Lady Antebellum, Carrie Underwood, Miranda Lambert.

USA – Gospel (Top 100) \$295

100 of the top Gospel radio stations across the US including all of the BDS and Mediabase monitored panel. These stations play music from artists such as Bebe and CeCe Winans, MaryMary, and Deitrick Haddon.

USA – Hot AC (Top 100) \$295

More than 55 radio stations across the US that requested inclusion on a list to receive new Christmas/Holiday themed music for airplay consideration on their seasonal playlist

USA – Mainstream Rock (Top 100) \$220

100 of the biggest market Mainstream Rock stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored and Indicator stations, and some format VIPs. These stations play current Rock tracks with a mix of recurrent and older Rock tracks. Core artists include Three Days Grace, Seether, Nickelback, and Hinder. There is overlap with some Active Rock songs.

USA – Rhythmic (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Rhythmic stations. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored, and



Indicator stations. Primarily, these stations play the Urban and Hip-Hop hits, but with a Top 40 presentation and sound. Core artists include Akon, T-Pain, Ciara, Sean Kingston.

USA – Triple A (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Adult Album Alternative (Triple A) stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored and Indicator stations with some format VIPs (Consultants, trade personnel, etc.). Core artists include Death Cab for Cutie, Mumford & Sons, Florence and the Machine.

USA – Ultimate College Package \$450

Hundreds of top College radio stations across the country including Mediaguide monitored stations and those with the biggest markets and/or signal power. These stations generally have multiple DJs who program many styles of music into their individual shows. Many of these stations have Block programming, which includes several hours of a certain style of music each week, including Alternative, Rock, Acoustic, Americana, Dance, Reggae, Hip Hop, Jazz, Urban, Electronic, and more.

USA – Urban (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Urban radio stations in the US. Includes all BDS/Mediabase monitored, or indicator stations. Urban stations play Urban and Hip-Hop hits, with a inner city sound and approach. Core artists include Wiz Khalifa, T.I., Beyonce, Chris Browne, Ne-Yo.

USA – Urban AC (Top 100) \$295

100 of the biggest market Urban AC radio stations in the US. Includes all the BDS/Mediabase monitored stations and indicators. Urban AC has roots in Soul and Gospel, and plays virtually no Rap and Hip-Hop. Core artists include Alicia Keys, Mary J Blige, Jill Scott, Maxwell, MaryMary.